

# CONFISCATION OF RELIGIOUS AND PRIVATE PROPERTY IN THE OCCUPIED TERRITORIES OF UKRAINE



## The Melitopol Case and the Broader Practice of the Russian Occupation Authorities

*Brief Analytical Report*

*11 September 2026*

### KEY FINDING

The seizure of church buildings in Melitopol is part of a broader system: repression of religious communities deemed disloyal is combined with the forced reassignment of churches, the seizure of private housing, and the redistribution of property and business assets. The “ownerless property” mechanism moves this practice from isolated abuses to a formalized occupation policy.

# 1. Melitopol: From the Seizure of Churches to Private Homes

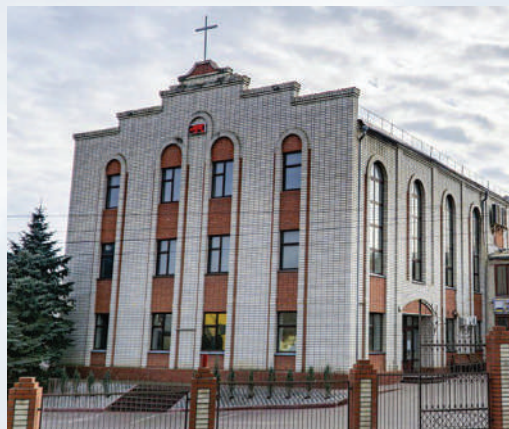
On 11 September 2022, armed representatives of the Russian occupation forces entered Grace Church in Melitopol during a Sunday worship service. Worshipers were registered and fingerprinted, the pastor was interrogated, and the church building was closed and later transferred for use by the occupation administration. Forum 18 and The Reckoning Project document this episode as part of systematic pressure on the city's Protestant communities.<sup>1</sup>

Grace Church was not an isolated case. According to religious freedom monitoring, the occupation authorities in Melitopol seized the buildings of at least 15 churches and shut down the activities of a number of communities. Some houses of worship were converted for use by administrative institutions or security structures.<sup>2</sup>

The repressive logic does not stop at church property. In August 2026, BBC Verify described the case of evangelical pastor Ihor Ivashchuk from Melitopol: after he left the city, his private home effectively became subject to the mechanism for seizing housing that the occupation authorities designate as "ownerless."<sup>3</sup> Another testimony from Melitopol, by Pastor Viktor Sergeyev, states that Russian officers moved into the homes of church ministers near the church and that property was looted. Thus, the seizure of the private homes of clergy and pastors is part of the same broader practice.<sup>4</sup>

## What the Melitopol Case Shows

- Church property is seized not merely as real estate, but as infrastructure for independent community life.
- Pressure on communities is combined with persecution of leaders, searches of homes, deportation, and confiscation of property.
- After an owner is expelled or leaves, the occupation system creates a legal mechanism for transferring that person's private property to others.



Melitopol, "Grace" Church >>>>  
"Ministry of Culture of the Zaporizhzhia Region"

*The historic building of Grace Evangelical Christian Church in Melitopol was constructed in 1914. In 1936, the Soviet authorities confiscated it, while the church's ministers were persecuted and executed. The building was returned to the congregation only in 1991. Since then, the church resumed worship services, developed a modern church complex, and became one of the city's prominent Protestant communities.*

*On September 11, 2022, Russian occupiers entered the church during a worship service, banned the congregation's activities, and forced its ministers to leave Melitopol. The cross was removed from the facade, the building was repainted, and the occupation authorities placed the so-called "Ministry of Culture of the Zaporizhzhia Region" there.*

1 Forum 18, 'OCCUPIED UKRAINE: Religious freedom survey, March 2025' (4 Mar. 2025): [https://www.forum18.org/archive.php?article\\_id=2963](https://www.forum18.org/archive.php?article_id=2963) ; The Reckoning Project, case 295, Melitopol: <https://sites.lsa.umich.edu/thereckoningproject/295-2/>

2 Mission Eurasia, 'Continued War Against Faith: Religious Genocide in the Occupied Territories of Ukraine, 2022–2025', sec. 6.5: <https://missioneurasia.org/continued-war-against-faith-religious-genocide-in-the-occupied-territories-of-ukraine-2022-2025/> ; Ukrainska Pravda, 29 May 2025: <https://www.pravda.com.ua/eng/news/2025/05/29/7514682/>

3 BBC Verify & BBC Russian, 'We have nowhere to return to: How Russia is seizing homes in occupied Ukraine' (7 Aug. 2026): [https://news.files.bbc.co.uk/include/newsspec/41090-mariupol\\_data-vj-scrollmation/english/app](https://news.files.bbc.co.uk/include/newsspec/41090-mariupol_data-vj-scrollmation/english/app)

4 RIA-Pivden, interview with Pastor Viktor Sergeyev: [https://ria-m.tv/ua/news/301269/bili\\_tak\\_scho\\_ridniy\\_batko\\_ne\\_vpiznav\\_sina\\_pastor\\_iz\\_melitopolya\\_rozpoviv\\_pro\\_zvirstva\\_okupantiv\\_%28video\\_foto%29.html](https://ria-m.tv/ua/news/301269/bili_tak_scho_ridniy_batko_ne_vpiznav_sina_pastor_iz_melitopolya_rozpoviv_pro_zvirstva_okupantiv_%28video_foto%29.html)

## 2. “Ownerless Property” as a Systemic Mechanism of Expropriation

In 2024–2026, the practice of seizing housing was formalized through occupation legislation. According to the Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights (OHCHR), since the beginning of the full-scale invasion, the occupation authorities have published notices concerning more than 38,000 apartments and houses as “potentially ownerless.” At least 6,156 properties have already been registered as “ownerless,” more than 80% of them in Mariupol. OHCHR explicitly states that this policy deprives displaced persons of their property, obstructs their return, and may make forced displacement effectively permanent.<sup>5</sup>

BBC Verify analyzed 516 lists published by the occupation authorities and identified 34,002 unique residential addresses included in “ownerless property” procedures. This figure is not identical to the UN data because of different methodology and timeframes, but it independently confirms the scale of the phenomenon.<sup>6</sup>

Human Rights Watch found that amendments to Russian legislation dated 15 December 2025 moved previously regional mechanisms for property seizure to the federal level. Owners with Ukrainian-issued documents were required to re-register their real estate in the Russian registry by 1 July 2026; housing declared “ownerless” may be transferred into the ownership of the occupation “regions” or municipalities and subsequently transferred to other persons.<sup>7</sup>

### Verified Indicators of Scale

| Indicator                                                                | Number           | Source                         |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Apartments/houses reported as “potentially ownerless”                    | more than 38,000 | OHCHR, 2026                    |
| Already registered as “ownerless”                                        | at least 6,156   | OHCHR, 2026                    |
| Unique residential addresses in 516 lists                                | <b>34 002</b>    | BBC Verify, 2026               |
| Private homes reported seized in the Melitopol district as early as 2023 | <b>674</b>       | U.S. Department of State, 2023 |

The U.S. Department of State’s 2023 report already noted reports of the seizure of 674 private homes in the Melitopol district. The same report documented the seizure and redistribution of property belonging to entrepreneurs who refused to re-register their businesses under the rules of the occupation authorities. In January 2026, the Center for Countering Disinformation also reported the seizure of assets belonging to Ukrainian entrepreneurs, including farmers, in occupied Kherson region under the guise of “nationalization.” This shows that housing, businesses, and religious property are different segments of the same process of asset redistribution in occupied territory.<sup>8</sup>

#### Yevpatoria, occupied Crimea: The Exaltation of the Holy Cross Church of the OCU >>> dismantling >>>> ruins.

*On July 21, 2024, the occupation authorities began dismantling the last Orthodox Church of Ukraine (OCU) church in Crimea. By the end of August, the structure had been effectively demolished.*



5 OHCHR/UN Human Rights Monitoring Mission in Ukraine, ‘Forced displacement from territory of Ukraine occupied by the Russian Federation’ (20 Mar. 2026), paras. 61–64: <https://ukraine.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/2026-04/2026-03-20%20OHCHR%20-%20Thematic%20report%20-%20Forced%20displacement.pdf>

6 BBC Verify & BBC Russian, methodology: 34,002 unique residential addresses identified in 516 published ‘ownerless property’ lists (7 Aug. 2026): [https://news.files.bbc.co.uk/include/newsspec/41090-mariupol\\_data-vj-scrollymation/english/app](https://news.files.bbc.co.uk/include/newsspec/41090-mariupol_data-vj-scrollymation/english/app)

7 Human Rights Watch, ‘Ukraine: Russia Illegally Seizing Property in Occupied Areas’ (26 May 2026): <https://www.hrw.org/news/2026/05/26/ukraine-russia-illegally-seizing-property-in-occupied-areas>

8 U.S. Department of State, 2023 Country Reports on Human Rights Practices, Ukraine—Russia-occupied Areas, sec. ‘Property Seizure and Restitution’: <https://2021-2025.state.gov/reports/2023-country-reports-on-human-rights-practices/ukraine/russia-occupied-areas/>; Center for Countering Disinformation, ‘Russians are looting businesses in TOT of Ukraine’ (16 Jan. 2026): <https://cpd.gov.ua/en/international-threats-en/usa/russians-are-looting-businesses-in-tot-of-ukraine/>

### 3. Religious Property, Forced Subordination, and the Russian Model of Control

Alongside the direct seizure of houses of worship, Russia is changing the institutional affiliation of religious infrastructure in the occupied territories. In April 2025, Ukraine's Ministry of Foreign Affairs reported the forced incorporation into the system of the Russian Orthodox Church of eight dioceses of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church—more than 1,600 parishes and 23 monasteries. These figures primarily describe institutional and canonical reassignment and should not automatically be interpreted as the same form of legal confiscation of every individual property.<sup>9</sup>

In September 2026, Human Rights Without Frontiers separately drew attention to the absorption of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church's religious infrastructure in Crimea and other occupied territories. The organization cites estimates of approximately 350 churches and monasteries in Crimea and more than 800 churches in other occupied areas that were removed from Ukrainian church jurisdiction or incorporated into the Russian system. Because of differences in methodology, these estimates should not be directly added to the figures provided by Ukraine's Ministry of Foreign Affairs.<sup>10</sup>

A similar logic operates within Russia itself toward religious groups that the state defines as disloyal or "extremist." On 31 July 2026, a Moscow court transferred 123 real estate assets belonging to Jehovah's Witnesses to the state—63 residential and commercial properties and 60 land plots.<sup>11</sup> According to current data from Jehovah's Witnesses themselves, at least 161 believers in Russia are being held in pretrial detention centers or penal colonies, or are serving sentences of forced labor in cases connected with their religious activity.<sup>12</sup>

#### Analytical Assessment

Taken together, these facts point to three interconnected processes: 1) the removal of religious communities that do not fit into the occupation hierarchy; 2) the seizure or repurposing of church property and forced ecclesiastical reassignment; and 3) the mass expropriation of private housing and business assets through "ownerless property" procedures. It is the third mechanism that makes the process self-perpetuating: every new wave of forced departure creates new properties that the occupation authorities can declare "abandoned."

This is also important for assessing religious freedom: the right to worship is inseparably linked to a community's right to access its place of worship and to a religious leader's right to safely use his own home and property. When a church is seized, a pastor or priest is expelled, and his home is transferred to another occupant, this is not an isolated property dispute but the destruction of the material foundation of freedom of conscience and the possibility of return.

Melitopol, "Word of Life" Church

>>>> barracks

>>>> police station



*For decades, the Word of Life Church in Melitopol was a place of worship and humanitarian assistance. On March 19, 2022, Russian soldiers arrested its pastor, Dmytro Bodyu. He was released after eight days in detention, but threats and persecution forced him and his family to leave the city.*

*In August 2022, the occupiers seized the church building. It was initially used as a military base, and later a unit of the occupation police was stationed there. The religious community has been banned from operating.*

<sup>9</sup> Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Ukraine, statement on persecution of clergy and religious communities in occupied territories (10 Apr. 2025): <https://mfa.gov.ua/en/news/zayava-mzs-shchodo-zvirstv-i-gonim-rosijskoyi-federaciyi-proti-duhovenstva-religijnih-gromad-ta-viryanna-timchasovo-okupovanih-teritoriyah-ukrayini>

<sup>10</sup> Human Rights Without Frontiers, 'Russia v. Ukraine: A shameful event at the United Nations in Geneva' (9 Sep. 2026): <https://hrwf.eu/russia-russia-v-ukraine-a-shameful-event-at-the-united-nations-in-geneva/>

<sup>11</sup> Reuters, 'Russian court confiscates 123 real estate assets belonging to Jehovah's Witnesses' (31 Jul. 2026): <https://www.reuters.com/world/russian-court-confiscates-123-real-estate-assets-belonging-jehovahs-witnesses-2026-07-31/>

<sup>12</sup> Jehovah's Witnesses, 'Jehovah's Witnesses Imprisoned for Their Faith—By Location', current as of Sep. 2026: <https://www.jw.org/en/news/region/global/jehovahs-witnesses-in-prison/>

## 4. The Contrast Between International Rhetoric and Actual Practice

On 8 September 2026, during the 63rd session of the UN Human Rights Council in Geneva, Russia's Permanent Mission organized an event devoted to criticism of the situation of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church in Ukraine. Human Rights Without Frontiers reported the participation of Mikhail Melekh, the Russian Foreign Ministry's special representative, and described the event as a Russian propaganda operation.<sup>13</sup>

Three days earlier, on 5 September, clergy of the Dnipropetrovsk Diocese of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church in Pavlohrad openly conducted the funeral service for two Ukrainian police officers, Oleksandr Hryhorenko and Serhii Shmatko. The National Police confirmed that they were killed on 3 September while documenting the aftermath of a Russian strike, when Russian forces carried out a follow-up attack.<sup>14</sup> The official statement of the Ukrainian Orthodox Church explicitly identifies a Russian attack as the cause of their deaths.<sup>15</sup>

This episode does not deny the existence of complex legal and church-state issues in Ukraine. However, it demonstrates the difference between debate within a democratic state and occupation practices in which religious communities are shut down, property is seized, clergy are persecuted, and private housing and businesses are transferred under the control of a new administration.

### Conclusions

- The seizure of churches in the occupied Ukrainian territories in 2022 was not a series of isolated episodes, but an early manifestation of a model of religious genocide. This practice subsequently expanded and has recently become increasingly evident.
- Likewise, beginning in 2014 with the annexation of Crimea and the occupation of parts of Donbas, the Russian authorities pursued the same practice through their proxies.
- In the occupied territories, the seizure of religious property is becoming increasingly intertwined with the mass expropriation of private houses, apartments, land plots, and business assets.
- The private homes of pastors and clergy are also subject to seizure, occupation by military personnel, or "ownerless property" procedures; this process is continuing.
- For international assessments of religious freedom, it is important to analyze not only laws and public statements, but also communities' actual access to places of worship, property rights, the freedom of religious ministers from persecution, and people's real ability to return home.

Religious freedom begins with concrete rights: to pray without armed men in a place of worship, not to fear searches or deportation, to keep one's church, home, and property—and to have the right to return to them.

Note: Quantitative indicators from different sources use different methodologies and observation periods; they are presented separately in this briefing and are not added together.

#### Melitopol, Melitopol Christian Church >>>> "Ministry of Youth and Sports of the Zaporizhzhia Region"



*For three decades, the congregation of Melitopol Christian Church developed one of the largest Protestant church complexes in Ukraine. Up to one thousand people gathered there for worship services.*

*At dawn on March 9, 2022, Russian soldiers stormed the complex, broke down the gates and doors, searched the church and the homes of its ministers, and interrogated the church leaders. The religious community was banned from operating. Later, the occupiers placed the so-called "Ministry of Youth and Sports" and a branch of the "Young Guard of United Russia" in the seized buildings.*

<sup>13</sup> Human Rights Without Frontiers, report on the Russian side-event at the 63rd UN Human Rights Council session (9 Sep. 2026): <https://hrwf.eu/russia-russia-v-ukraine-a-shameful-event-at-the-united-nations-in-geneva/>

<sup>14</sup> National Police of Ukraine, 'Police officers of Dnipropetrovsk region bid farewell to fallen police officers Oleksandr Hryhorenko and Serhii Shmatko' (5 Sep. 2026): <https://npu.gov.ua/news/politseiski-dnipropetrovshchyny-poproshchalsia-iz-zahyblymy-politseiskymy-oleksandrom-hryhorenkom-ta-serhiem-shmatkom>

<sup>15</sup> Ukrainian Orthodox Church, 'In Pavlohrad, two law enforcement officers who died as a result of a Russian attack were laid to rest' (8 Sep. 2026): <https://uoc-news.church/2026/09/08/u-pavlogradi-proveli-u-vichnist-dvov-pravooxoronciv-yaki-zaginuli-vnaslidok-rosijskoji-ataki/>

**Mariupol: “Good Changes” Church  
>>> “Komsomolets” Cinema.**



*In 2016, the Good Changes Church community purchased the abandoned building of the former soviet cinema, renovated it with its own resources, and transformed it into a modern church, youth, and social center. The congregation was well known in Mariupol for its broad social outreach, pro-family initiatives, and programs that helped hundreds of people return to a healthy way of life. Its senior pastor, Gennadiy Mokhnenko, founded the Pilgrim Republic children’s rehabilitation center, where thousands of children*

*and teenagers received love, support, and a chance for a happier life.*

*After the occupation of Mariupol, the Russian authorities seized the building from the religious community. Church members and ministers were forced to leave the city. In 2025, the occupation administration repurposed the former church center as a municipal cinema, restoring its Soviet-era name, “Komsomolets.”*

**Makiivka, Donetsk Region: “New Life” Church >>> Civil Registry Office**



*Following the occupation of the Donbas in 2014, the “New Life” Baptist Church in Makiivka was designated as “ownerless property.” In January 2019, a district civil registry office was officially opened in its premises.*

*erty.” Some religious buildings were previously used as barracks or ammunition depots, or were even slated to be converted into a boxing school.*

*Similarly, Jehovah’s Witnesses’ Kingdom Halls in Horlivka, Debaltseve, and other cities were seized on the grounds that they were allegedly “unused” or showed “signs of being ownerless prop-*

*erty.” In Melitopol in 2023, the cross was sawed off a Protestant church building, the “fish” emblem (an early Christian symbol representing Christ’s disciples) was cut out, and the structure was converted into a sambo training center.*

**The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints meetinghouse in Donetsk  
>>> “Russian House” cultural center**

*A meetinghouse of The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints in Donetsk was built in the early 2000s on the site of a ruined old soviet cinema.*

*In 2014, following the seizure of power in Donetsk by Russian-backed military forces, all Mormon meetinghouses were illegally confiscated. In 2021, a Russian cultural center named “Russkiy Dom” (Russian House) was opened in this building.*

*Three other Mormon buildings constructed before the war in the Kuibyshevskiy, Proletarskiy, and Kirovskiy districts of Donetsk were also confiscated and are currently used as civil registry offices.*



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